The Bridge to Zero – Protecting Hong Kong's Self-Employed Drivers in the Age of Oil Crisis

International oil prices have surged over 55% since the outbreak of US-Iran war.[1] The blockade of the Strait of Hormuz has disrupted oil supply, particularly diesel, as one-fifth of the world's oil flows through this strategic waterway.[2] Hong Kong has no oil reserves. Local petrol and diesel prices spiked to a record $32 per litre[3] within weeks. For self-employed minibus drivers and truck drivers, this was not a mere news headline. It was an immediate survival crisis. Some minibus drivers now skip lunch to afford the fuel.[4]

Context

Hong Kong's transport sector is the second-largest source of greenhouse gas emissions, accounting for nearly 20% of the city's total.[5] The government has committed to carbon neutrality by 2050. Yet oil and coal account for 86% of transport fuel,[6] revealing Hong Kong's dependence on imported oil with no reserves.[7] The current oil crisis makes a permanent exit from fossil fuels necessary.

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[1] Graham, E., & Shan, L. Y. (2026, April 21). *A timeline of how the Iran war shook oil prices — and what comes next*. CNBC. https://www.cnbc.com/2026/04/21/oil-price-iran-war-middle-east.html
[2] Oil prices trim gains after UAE exits OPEC, OPEC+ by Reuters. (n.d.). https://ca.investing.com/news/commodities-news/oil-prices-rise-as-no-end-to-iran-war-standoff-seems-in-sight-4590293
[3] The Standard (2026, March 10). 'World's priciest oil': Record oil prices fuel HK EV rush amid long burden. *The Standard*. https://www.thestandard.com.hk/news/article/326321/Worlds-priciest-oil-Record-oil-prices-fuel-HK-EV-rush-amid-long-burden; and actual data is peer reviewed
[4] TVB News (2026, March 10). *HK minibus sector may increase fares in response to rising oil prices*. TVB News. https://news.tvb.com/tc/pearlnews/69b012ee2dd2502b5884800a/TVB%20News-HK-minibus-sector-may-increase-fares-in-response-to-rising-oil-prices
[5] RTHK 31 Green Future - Zero Emission. (n.d.). https://www.rthk.hk/tv/dtt31/programme/greenfuture_eng/episode/1018430
[6] Hong Kong Special Administrative Region Government. (2025). *Hong Kong Energy End-use Data 2025,* p.70. https://www.emsd.gov.hk/filemanager/en/content_762/HKEEUD2025.pdf
[7] *LCQ5: Energy supply in Hong Kong*. (n.d.). https://www.info.gov.hk/gia/general/202603/25/P2026032500478.htm

Electric alternatives cost over one million dollars – far beyond what self-employed drivers can afford. The government's three-month fuel subsidy provides instant relief,[8] but extending it indefinitely would lock Hong Kong into fossil fuel dependency. Withdrawing it too soon would bankrupt thousands of drivers. The city is caught between an immediate survival crisis and a long-term climate imperative.

Solution: "Bridge to Zero" Program

This is not an either-or situation. I propose a two-phase "Bridge to Zero" program that protects self-employed drivers while accelerating the electric transition.

Phase one focuses on immediate relief. The government has already implemented a three-month fuel subsidy[9], which has significantly eased pressure — a Tuen Mun resident bus operator recently withdrew its fare increase application.[10] I contend this is a good move and should be extended to 6 months, or until diesel prices return to pre-war levels, to keep the fuel affordable for struggling commercial drivers. However, this is not permanent fossil fuel support. It is a time-limited bridge to combat the price surge.

Phase two focuses on conversion to electric vehicles to eradicate fossil fuel dependency. The key to accelerating the electric commercial vehicle adoption is accessibility. Given the government has fully waived the first registration tax on new electric commercial vehicles,[11] I propose launching a "one-for-one replacement scheme" on commercial vehicles that provides additional concessions when drivers scrap old fossil fuel vehicles for new electric ones. This scheme has proven highly successful

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[8] *Consumer prices 'accelerated somewhat' in March - RTHK*. (n.d.). https://news.rthk.hk/rthk/en/component/k2/1852191-20260423.htm
[9] Ibid.
[10] The Standard. (2026b, April 9). Govt fuel subsidies prompt Tuen Mun resident bus operator to withdraw fare hike application. *The Standard*. https://www.thestandard.com.hk/news/article/328939/Govt-fuel-subsidies-prompt-Tuen-Mun-resident-bus-operator-to-withdraw-fare-hike-application
[11] *Promotion of electric vehicles | Environmental Protection Department*. (n.d.). https://www.epd.gov.hk/epd/english/environmentinhk/air/promotion_ev/promotion_ev.html#Measure

for private cars, quadrupling electric private car ownership to over 140,000 vehicles.[12] It is now time to launch it for commercial vehicles like trucks and minibuses.

Critics may argue that any fuel subsidy delays the energy transition. I accept this as valid – indefinite fuel subsidy does hinder energy transition. However, a transition that bankrupts self-employed drivers is politically unsustainable and morally indefensible, violating United Nations Sustainable Development Goals 1,8, and 10.[13] Fuel subsidy is necessary to protect drivers' livelihoods during the transition. We cannot sacrifice the vulnerable in energy transition.

Others may critique that electric commercial vehicles are not ready for Hong Kong's hilly terrain and limited range. I understand that electric commercial vehicles face greater challenges on Hong Kong's slopes than private cars. However, electric vehicle technology is already sufficient. The expected range of a fully loaded electric truck is as high as 400km,[14] which is more than enough for Hong Kong, let alone minibuses. The energy transition is already technically feasible.

Impact and Next Step

This solution benefits multiple stakeholders. Self-employed drivers gain immediate relief and a realistic path to electric ownership. This proposed solution would alleviate the burden on commercial drivers, as over 80% have reported mental and physical health impacts from high oil prices.[15] The climate and general public also benefit, as commercial vehicle electrification reduces roadside NO2

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[12] *'One-for-One Replacement' scrapped for private EVs - RTHK*. (n.d.). https://news.rthk.hk/rthk/en/component/k2/1844997-20260225.htm
[13] *THE 17 GOALS | Sustainable Development*. (n.d.). https://sdgs.un.org/goals
[14] Shoman, W., Yeh, S., Sprei, F., Plötz, P., & Speth, D. (2023). Battery electric long-haul trucks in Europe: Public charging, energy, and power requirements. *Transportation Research Part D: Transport and Environment*, *121*, 103825.
[15] *HK drivers feel pain as fuel prices soar amid global oil shock*. (n.d.). Chinadailyhk. https://www.chinadailyhk.com/hk/article/632366

emissions, which disproportionately affect dense neighbourhoods like Mong Kok and Kwun Tong, giving us cleaner air to breathe, especially in crowded areas.

The next step is immediate and achievable. Simply write an email to the Transport and Logistics Bureau, "Extend fuel subsidies for self-employed drivers. Launch one-for-one replacement scheme for commercial vehicles. Protect the vulnerable in the energy transition."

Conclusion

Hong Kong did not cause the US-Iran war. Self-employed drivers did not cause climate change. But both are paying the price. A just transition should not ask the most vulnerable to sacrifice first. The government has already shown leadership with the diesel subsidy[16]. Now, it must complete the bridge: extend the fuel subsidy and fund the conversion, forging Hong Kong towards a cleaner future.

(Word count: 748)

[16] Ibid 8.

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